

ory, but writing by hand improves your fine motor skills, and has been observed to reduce stress as well. Some studies have suggested that writing by hand actually improves creative thought, and might actually help us slow down mental aging! In extreme cases, severely depressed people have been found to have significantly better mental health benefits if they write about their feelings for just 30 minutes a day!

So what are you waiting for? Get out a pen and paper and just start by copying out this entire section about writing. Do it in cursive style, and pretend that you're going to get marked for it. We'll even dangle a carrot for you – click a picture of your handwriting, post it on social media and send us the link (editor@digit.in). We will give a few lucky readers who do this a surprise gift.

■ OLD IS GOLD

This saying has not held true for a long, long time now, especially not when it comes to technology. Yes, most of our parents will tell us of a time when things were built like brick walls and lasted a lifetime, but then those devices were also as dumb as a brick wall, and about as big and heavy as well! Sure, a calculator made in the 1980s might still work, but then again, it's a calculator! Who cares? The next time someone tells you that old is gold, ask them to travel by bullock cart instead of a car or a

train, and then repeat the same line after the journey.

That said, technology has killed our ability to buy a device and forget about it for years. While this may still hold true for some things, such as an air conditioner, a refrigerator or a washing machine, which are still made to last at least five to seven years, the rest of the gadgetry in our houses are made to last considerably shorter times. Phones especially are built to last about 4 years max, and start underperforming in about two years. And we're not just talking about battery power dwindling and therefore battery life and performance falling... we're also talking about actual zippiness of the phone, thanks to the updated software that we all have to update to for security purposes. More apps get loaded into the system and clog it up, new features for your favourite apps are developed with the latest generation of hardware in mind, and you either have to live without those features or else suffer laggy performance. Eventually, we're all forced into buying an upgraded phone about once every two or three years, and the cycle repeats.

Planned obsolescence is a term that describes how manufacturers purposely design products in a way to force people to replace them after a set interval of time. They do this by using materials that are of a cheaper quality that will give way sooner, or

by stopping the manufacture of spare parts which means products are not repairable after a point. However, it's not just planned obsolescence that dictates our desire to own the latest and greatest, it's also good marketing and hyping up of new features that helps to make us salivate over the latest models. All of this has an effect on the planet and our wallets, but we're getting to that...

■ THE PLANET

It's no secret that we humans create a lot of e-waste, and the more gadgets and gizmos we buy, the more we add to the pile. Disposing of e-waste or repurposing and recycling it all is a hard process, and can have some toxic waste byproducts. Besides, it is not just when we throw stuff away that we harm the planet, but also when we go out and buy something new. That new product has a carbon footprint attached to it, and it has its own tiny share of all the mining that went into producing the metals and rare earth elements it contains, the oil that was drilled and brought to the surface in order to make the plastics on the gadget, and of course all of the associated energy waste that it generates because of the electric charges it will require over its lifetime.

The problem is that as we mentioned in the last sub-headline, old is not gold, so things just aren't built to last for a long time anymore, and technological advancement makes them obsolete in under 5 years. In order to keep making profits, companies are stuck in a forced innovation cycle in order to entice or even force people to upgrade their personal technology, and let's face it, we're more than happy to oblige just to be able to get a short lived dopamine rush. Meanwhile, the planet is happy to offer up its insides to us in order for us to get a new phone every year, because the planet doesn't care. It will be here long after we go extinct.

Thankfully we are more aware of this problem than we were a decade ago, and at least some of us are trying to hold the companies we buy from accountable to higher standards of eco friendliness. What we really need



Credit: Saiko

A timekeeping devices that will easily outlast a generation, instead of going obsolete next year